

Title Page

Divine Purpose in Human Suffering: Theodicy and Moral Formation in Job and Mencius

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Abstract

This essay reads the book of Job alongside *Mengzi* 6B15 (the fifteenth section of "Gaozi II") through cross-textual hermeneutics, arguing that the two texts generate not a synthesis but a productive tension over the role of suffering in moral formation. The most important precedent, Lee Yearley's 1981 pairing of Job with Confucius, worked within an Aristotelian frame and concluded that virtue can be held independent of reward. I take three further steps: I replace that imported frame with Archie Lee's cross-textual method, which lets each text argue in its own idiom; I substitute *Mengzi* 6B15 for the *Analects*, a text far more explicit about the pedagogy of adversity; and I make Job 23:10 ("when he has tested me, I shall come out like gold," כִּי בִּחְנִי אֵצֶל אֱלֹהִים) the hinge of the argument. Read with Mencian eyes, Job's metallurgical image betrays a teleological instinct that Greco-Roman frameworks—Stoic endurance, Platonic ascent, Leibnizian optimism—have tended to obscure. The structural parallel between *tummâ* (תְּמָה, integrity) and *duan* (端, the moral "sprouts"), both qualities that suffering refines rather than creates, is the essay's central contribution. Job restrains the Mencian drift toward over-systematization; *Mengzi* keeps the Joban narrative from collapsing into nihilism.

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